marched into Toulouse in triumph on October 1, 1217.[4]

Meanwhile, Innocent III had died suddenly of an embolism, aged fifty-six, while visiting the central Italian town of Perugia. The cardinals of Rome went immediately into conclave to elect his successor, neglecting to bury the dead pope's body; two days later, the theologian Jacques de Vitry found Innocent III's body decomposing in the church of St. Lawrence, stripped of its gold-trimmed robes by thieves. His successor, the Roman priest Honorius III, immediately put most of his energies into the proposed Crusade, paying little attention to Languedoc except to authorize the creation of a new monastic order led by Dominic Guzman. This Order of Preachers, soon known simply as Dominicans, renewed Dominic's efforts to conquer the Languedoc heresy by converting, rather than murdering, its inhabitants.[5]

Simon de Montfort laid siege to Toulouse, but his constant assaults on the city's walls were always driven back by the citizens, who joined Raymond's knights in building new defenses and operating the mangonels, catapults that hurled boulders over the city's walls at the attackers: "Knights and citizens handled the stones," says the contemporary *Song of the Cathar Wars*, "as did noble ladies and their daughters, young men, little girls and boys, everyone, great and small, and they sang songs and ballads as they worked." Nine months into the siege, a stone pitched from a mangonel worked "by little girls and men's wives" struck Simon de Montfort between the eyes and shattered his skull. A knight nearby hurriedly covered the body with a cape, but word of Montfort's death spread at once, and his men immediately abandoned the siege.[6]

Toulouse rejoiced, but when Honorius III heard the news he announced a revival of the Crusade against Languedoc. Philip II of France sent a sizable force of archers and knights under the command of Prince Louis (newly returned from his unsuccessful bid to seize the English throne) to join Montfort's son Amaury, aged twenty-three, in a renewed attack on the rebellious southern provinces.[7]

This campaign failed, disastrously. In one of the first engagements of the resurrected Albigensian war, Louis and Amaury besieged and captured the small town of Marmande. Probably hoping to terrify the rest of Languedoc into surrender, the two men authorized the massacre of Marmande's inhabitants. "No one was left alive, man or woman, young or old," says an eyewitness account. "Limbs and bodies, flesh and blood, broken fragments of human organs lay in every open place. The ground, the streets . . . were red with blood."[8]

The strategy backfired. Resistance stiffened. Prince Louis took his army